CAN YOGI MAKE HISTORY?

Yogi Adityanath is poised on the edge of a future that can change Indian politics. He brims with optimism, but a resurgent Akhilesh Yadav is giving him the battle of his life in UP

BY **RAJ CHENGAPPA** *WITH* **PRASHANT SRIVASTAVA IN LUCKNOW** *Photograph by* **BANDEEP SINGH**

Yogi Adityanath, the ochre-robed, shaven-headed monk-turned-politician, faces the biggest ever test of his life—but seems unfazed by the magnitude of the challenge. For five years, as chief minister of Uttar Pradesh, he has ruled India's most populous state with an iron fist sheathed in a saffron glove that was never far from controversy. Now the moment of reckoning has come, with 152 million voters about to decide whether to give him a second term or usher in a new dispensation. At his official residence in Lucknow, seated on a sofa draped with a saffron towel, flanked by a bronze statue of Lord Ram with a bow and arrow and a *pichhwai* of Lord Krishna, Adityanath makes for a picture brimming with optimism. "I've never lost and never accepted defeat," he says.